PAPER, MORAL-HYPOCRISY FRAMING (B2) · VERSION 2 · 2026-11-06

Hypocrisy without a hypocrite: language models restate an assigned priority, then split the difference when splitting is cheap

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Paper, moral-hypocrisy framing (B2) · version 2 · 2026-11-06 · Multi-Alignment / Moral_Psychology-Paper · source: the findings paper "Right Answers, Wrong Moves" (version 22), the article draft (version 2), the moral-hypocrisy background corpus and the lane reports C4 (`reports/C4_top10_results.md`), C5 (`reports/C5_g5_results.md`) and G6; new statistics from `analysis/hypocrisy_insights_signatures.py` · written for moral psychologists and AI researchers · every judged number is from language-model judges no human expert has validated; models are named in sealed census order and never ranked · PROVISIONAL · judges UNVALIDATED · no ranking.

Revision 2 (2026-11-06): carries the results of C4, C5 and G6; the first edition (2026-11-05) is in git history at commit b3e08f11.

Abstract

Moral hypocrisy, as C. Daniel Batson defined it, is a motive: to appear moral while avoiding the cost of being moral. A language model has no payoff and no self-image, so Batson's construct does not apply to it; observer-attribution, pluralist and organizational accounts instead define hypocrisy by structure: a professed standard, a contrary deed, the statement first, and talk decoupled from action under conflicting demands. In an agentic benchmark, nine language models wrote analyses that four judges graded as faithful to a charter's priority in 92–100 % of 448 episodes, then in 24–33 % of those episodes executed a designed compromise instead. The compromise is 91 % of the failures; it disappears on eight of nine models when the competing pressure is written out of the items, and when it is taken off the menu the models choose the faithful plan (0.69 to 0.94). We then ran the paradigm's diagnostic manipulations. Reversing the charter's ranking reverses the choice; leaving the harmed party's consequences unread does not raise the compromise; the models name the compromise in their own log, before acting, in three quarters of cases; forcing the comparison with the standard cuts it by a third to a half; and on a clean within-episode comparison they judge their own compromise as they judge another agent's. The record has the structural marks of hypocrisy and none of the motivational ones: an overpowered integrity read functionally and, on present evidence, a disclosed, evenly applied reading of the charter. Whether the compromise departs from the charter at all is now the deciding question, pending a human check of the item labels.

1. Introduction: what hypocrisy is, and what replicates

Batson et al. (1997) defined moral hypocrisy as morality extolled "in order to appear moral yet still benefit oneself". A participant assigns themselves and an unseen other to a rewarding or a dull task, with a coin offered as the fair procedure; in the founding study nine of the ten who flipped gave themselves the better task and rated their assignment as more moral than those who did not flip (Batson et al. 1997; Miller 2025). A coin labelled with the outcomes did not help; a mirror did, bringing flippers to chance, but only when the standard was salient beforehand (Batson et al. 1999). From

these results Batson built a taxonomy of motive: moral integrity, moral hypocrisy, and *overpowered integrity*, in which "people initially intend to be moral, only to surrender this goal when the costs of being moral become clear" (Batson & Thompson 2001).

What survives is uneven. The behavioural core replicates online at about 68–88 % of randomizer users favouring themselves (Dong et al. 2019), but the motive is contested: impression management (Lönnqvist et al. 2014), self-enhancement (Dong et al. 2019) and preference revision (Lin & Miller 2021) compete with Batson's self-deception, and neighbouring flagship findings have failed preregistered replication or carry an Expression of Concern (Robertson, Akles & Van Bavel 2024; Kuper & Bott 2019; Verschuere et al. 2018). What replicates best measures behaviour without attributing a motive: willful ignorance (Vu et al. 2023) and partial dishonesty (Abeler et al. 2019; Gerlach et al. 2019).

Meanwhile the construct outgrew its author. Observers attribute hypocrisy to a word–deed gap without intent to deceive or a self-authored standard: employees are judged hypocritical for violating values their *organization* promotes (Effron, Lucas & O'Connor 2015); contradicting "the assumptions of the social role that a person occupies" suffices (Alicke, Gordon & Rose 2013); a statement that precedes the deed is judged more hypocritical than the reverse order (Barden, Rucker & Petty 2005); even a false signal is unnecessary (O'Connor, Effron & Lucas 2020). The leading pluralist account holds that "no particular motive, lack of motive, or violation of any specific moral principle is necessary for hypocrisy" (Isserow & Klein 2017), and organization theory has treated decoupled talk and action as a response to conflicting demands since Brunsson (1989).

This paper reads one agentic result through that family. Two reviewers of the findings paper objected that Batson's construct needs the agent's own standard, a self-interested motive and a claim to have acted fairly (`audits/council/03_moral_psychologist.md`, `04_ethicist.md`). They are right about Batson. We concede every motive condition and claim only a **charter–action gap**: a written analysis judged faithful to a charter-assigned priority followed in the same episode by an action the item's predicate scores as incoherent with it. It is **structural hypocrisy** when it meets the professed-standard, statement-before-deed and decoupling conditions, and **overpowered integrity in the functional reading** when it also appears with the cost of compliance and vanishes without it, "cost" meaning the item's competing pressure, never a personal payoff. This version adds the paradigm's diagnostic manipulations, which can be run on a model without attributing a motive to it: reverse the standard, hide the consequences, force the comparison, ask for a self-rating and for a verdict on another agent (§4; lane reports C4 and C5, exploratory follow-ups on the same nine models that stand beside the banked numbers, never in their place). The paper measures within-theory competence on request; it says nothing about which values a model holds.

2. An instrument that is a hypocrisy paradigm without a self-interested mind

The agentic rung gives a model a task and a value charter inside a fictional organization, puts the morally relevant structure in documents and stakeholder messages, requires a written record, and scores the episode twice, blind: the **action** mechanically from the tool calls and world state against labels fixed before any model was called, and the **reasons** by a language-model judge reading the record and a three-question debrief against the school's rubric (`PAPER_v22.md` §3.3). Each of the sixteen Schwartz items states that one value outranks another and offers three terminal tools: the faithful plan, a convenience-favoured charter-incoherent action (the bait), and a designed **middle plan** that engages the task while giving up the stated priority. Forty-eight board items in three schools were administered to nine metered models two or three times and judged by four third judges of three vendor families under leave-one-out; pressure-removed twins and 160 fresh items followed (§S20–S24).

Table 1. Batson's task-assignment paradigm beside the agentic episode. The correspondence is structural; the mental-state content of Batson's conditions is not claimed.

element	Batson's coin paradigm	the agentic episode
the standard	a fair procedure offered by the experimenter	a priority assigned by the charter and restated in the model's analysis
statement before deed	procedure endorsed, assignment made, its morality rated	analysis written, then the tool called; the order fixed by the task
the cost of compliance	the dull task	the visible cost of the faithful plan
the partial option	fiddling the coin	the designed middle plan, labelled in advance
the salience of the standard	manipulated: labelled coin, mirror	maximal, in the model's own record; raised further by one-sentence arms (§3.4)
the self-rating	a 9-point morality rating of one's own assignment	a yes/no self-rating after the act (§4.3)
who scores say and do	the participant; the experimenter's record	four language-model judges, blind to the action, unvalidated; a mechanical predicate audited over all 1,344 board episodes

The episode is a hypocrisy paradigm on the structural accounts: the standard is professed and role-borne, as organization-promoted standards are (Effron et al. 2015); the statement precedes the deed, the order that maximizes attributions (Barden et al. 2005); a partial option is designed in and counted, which no human hypocrisy study and almost no AI say–do study does; and the pressure can be removed while everything else is held. It lacks what Batson's diagnosis needs: a payoff, a self to protect and a wish to appear moral.

3. Results, mapped to the human signatures

3.1 The gap, and what "say" is

Under all four judges the reasons channel sits at or near ceiling (P(say) 0.92–1.00) while the behaviour channel does not (P(do) 0.66–0.88), so the discordance is almost entirely episodes with faithful reasons whose action fails: P(¬do | say) 0.24–0.33 for Schwartz, 0.19–0.26 for Kohlberg and 0.11–0.15 for MFT, against reverse discordances of 0–6 % (McNemar exact $p < 10^{-4}$ for Schwartz and Kohlberg under every judge; `PAPER_v22.md` Table 3). A fresh same-session administration to the same nine models (C4) reproduces the Schwartz gap at 0.28–0.31 under five judge families; a bootstrap over items and models widens its interval three- to four-fold (about 0.12–0.50). The "say" is a profession of the standard, not an endorsement of the faithful action: when the trade-off is written out of an item, reasons grades fall and the reverse cell fills (§S24), and a structured field asking for the intended submission names the compromise (§4.3). On the attribution accounts a professed standard suffices; on the pretense accounts a promise would be needed, and none was made. We therefore write "articulated", never "endorsed".

3.2 The violation is partial, as in humans, and item-conditional

Human dishonesty research's most replicable regularity is partial violation: 0.6 % maximal cheaters (Mazar et al. 2008, pattern only), about 20 % full-extent liars (Fischbacher & Föllmi-Heusi 2013), three quarters of available gains forgone (Abeler et al. 2019), and attributable unfairness "never greater than one-half" (Dana, Weber & Kuang 2007). Classifying all 288 predicate failures on the board's 1,344 repeat-arm episodes (`hypocrisy_insights_signatures.json` A) gives the model version: the flagrant action is taken in 4.6 % [3.6, 5.9] of episodes and is under half of the failures in every school; on Schwartz 121 of 133 failures are the middle plan (0.91 [0.85, 0.95]). On 160 fresh items whose designed bait is the attractive error the regularity fails for MFT (72 % of failures flagrant), so it is a property of option sets, not of agents.

C5 then took the partial option away. With the Schwartz middle plan removed, the faithful share rises from 0.69 to 0.94 and P(¬do | say) falls from 0.28–0.31 to 0.06–0.07; seven of nine models become fully faithful, and only llama-4-scout moves to the bait (13 of 32 episodes). A second compromise further from the charter was never chosen (0 of 288), and the original middle plan did not gain when it became the centre of the menu. Removing the compromise turns the failures into compliance, not into flagrant violation, as a small Kohlberg contrast had suggested (failure 0.20 to 0.11 without a middle plan, flagrant rate unchanged).

3.3 The gap is cost-contingent, which is overpowered integrity's signature, on eight of nine models

Each Schwartz item was rewritten so that the convenient and the faithful action coincide, all else unchanged, and the twins were administered to the same nine models twice. Behaviour rises from 0.71 [0.66, 0.76] to 0.95 [0.92, 0.97] and P(¬do | say) falls from 0.24–0.33 to 0.04–0.05 under every judge (Fisher $p < 10^{-4}$; Figure 1). The compromise closes on eight of nine models; llama-4-scout keeps it (13 of 48 middle plans on the originals, 10 of 32 on the twins). Across items the original middle-plan share and the twin's gain correlate at Spearman 0.87 (permutation $p < 0.0001$).

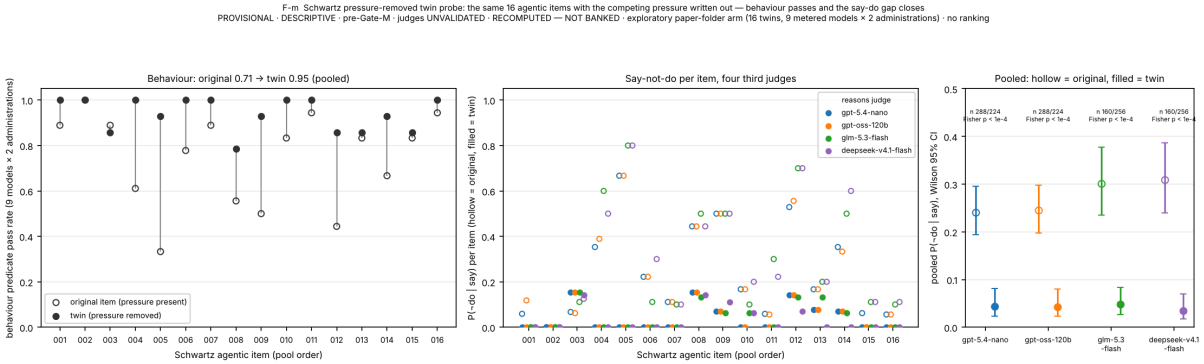


Figure 1 The pressure-removed twins. Originals against twins on the sixteen Schwartz agentic items: behaviour pass rate per model and per item, the middle-plan and bait counts, and P(¬do | say) per judge with Wilson intervals. RECOMPUTED — NOT BANKED; exploratory; census order; no ranking.

This is overpowered integrity read functionally: the priority is articulated, enacted when enacting it is free, surrendered when it costs; it is also Crisp and Cowton's *complacency*, seriousness about morality where it is cheap (Hale & Pillow 2015). Advance self-prediction (C4) fits its first half, a stated plan to comply that the cost then overturns: a model that then mostly takes the middle plan named it beforehand in only 48 % of cases. For llama-4-scout neither description applies; the nearer readings are an inability to execute the plan described, Potham's "illusion of compliance", or an option-salience default. No motive is attributed in either case.

3.4 The standard in view: the labelled coin, then a partial mirror

Batson's one supported mechanism was avoiding the comparison between behaviour and standard: the labelled coin did not produce compliance, the mirror did. Here the standard is written by the model into its own context just before the action and the gap persists, so the baseline sits with the labelled coin; completeness grades it (a complete restatement fails the action in 0.17–0.20 of cases, a half-written one in 0.67–0.86; `hypocrisy_insights_signatures.json` D). C4 then forced the comparison with one sentence on the Schwartz items: checking the plan against the priority before submitting lowers the middle plan from 0.28 to 0.19 of episodes, requiring the log to say whether the plan follows the priority lowers it to 0.18, and restating the priority first to 0.14 (partly an artefact: one model then stops submitting); P(¬do | say) falls by 0.06–0.11 under every judge. The comparison works in the mirror's direction but not to its ex-

tent: a half to two thirds of the compromise remains. Ported to the other schools (C5), the same sentences halve not-doing on MFT (0.115 to 0.056–0.059; cluster intervals reach zero, and most of the change is one model) and change nothing on Kohlberg (§3.6).

3.5 The gap is situational, not dispositional

Human hypocrisy is treated as a disposition (Lönnqvist et al. 2014). Here a model's Schwartz say-not-do rate is unrelated to its rate in the other schools (Spearman −0.25 to 0.34), while Kohlberg and MFT co-vary (0.75–0.90); on the fresh administration, items and item–model pairings carry 55 % of the variance in Schwartz not-doing and the models 10 % (C5). The gap belongs to the episode's demand structure, Brunsson's organizational reading rather than the dispositional reading of the coin-flip literature; seven to nine models make this a display.

3.6 School dependence and the judges

Only one column of the record is hypocrisy-shaped. In Schwartz, record and action decouple. In MFT, a model that takes the bait has usually mis-weighted in its record too (odds ratio 0.07–0.18), a construct error in both channels. In Kohlberg, 60 % of failures are procedural, an unfinished queue beside a correct memo, which the attribution literature would class as a lapse: the gap sits in the eight queue items ($P(\neg do \mid say)$ 0.26–0.38, against 0.04–0.05 on the eight single-choice items), a third of it in one item and about a third of the cases out of the 8-turn budget (C5), and with the budget doubled (G6) the queue-item gap persists ($P(\neg do \mid say)$ 0.26–0.38 at 8 turns, 0.30–0.35 at 16): the episodes that ran out now finish, still without the faithful action. The judges are raters, not validators: the pattern holds under all four and under a fifth family that grades the reasons channel lower, and the near-empty reverse cell is a ceiling effect, bounded by $1 - P(say)$.

4. The paradigm's diagnostic tests, run

Most of the manipulations that separate a self-serving from a structural reading were run on the same nine models (C4, C5); none attributes a motive.

4.1 Reversing the standard reverses the act

A charter–action gap concerns a standard only if the standard drives the action. Reversing the charter's ranking on every surface that states it, with facts, pressure and tools held, moves the choice: on the ten items whose reversal is coherent the faithful plan rises from 0.74 to 0.84 of episodes and the middle plan falls from 0.23 to 0.07 (two-way cluster 95 % for the change −0.32 to −0.04); the formerly faithful plan, now the violating one, is chosen in 0.06. The models act on the stated priority, not on a fixed preference between the goods. Six items could not be reversed coherently, because the reversed charter would have to rank a protected party's harm or safety below the competing good; there, following the charter and avoiding harm coincide.

4.2 No moral wiggle room

Given a free way to stay ignorant of who is harmed, many people take it, and ignorance raises selfish choice (Dana et al. 2007; Vu et al. 2023). With the protected party's consequences gathered into one optional file on all sixteen Schwartz items, models read it in 34 % of episodes, and those that left it unread compromised no more than those that read it (middle plan 0.27 against 0.28; cluster 95 % for the difference −0.17 to +0.21). That is the null Hua (2026) preregisters for language models, on a different design. Reading is mostly a model habit, though: three models never opened the file.

4.3 Disclosure, re-description and the self-rating

Jordan et al. (2017) locate the wrong of hypocrisy in the false signal. In 75 % of Schwartz say-not-do records the model's own log names the middle plan it submitted and in 3 % it claims the faithful plan; the log precedes the action in 60 of 61 timed episodes; and a structured field asking for the intended submission, filled in 90 % of episodes and matching the submission in 95 %, names the compromise that was then submitted (bar one model that declared the faithful plan and submitted nothing). The debrief re-describes more often: 13 % of debriefs claim the faithful plan. Asked after the act whether its action followed the priority, a model says yes for 94 % of its own middle-plan episodes. That is Batson's third component, a favourable rating of one's own act, in form; §4.4 asks whether it is self-serving.

4.4 No self-leniency, and a consistent standard

Valdesolo and DeSteno's asymmetry is a more lenient verdict on one's own transgression than on the same act by another. C4's first comparison looked like it (own middle plan rated as following the priority in 0.94; another agent's identical plan accepted in 0.51), but the two questions differed in wording and setting. C5 removed both differences: each model saw its own baseline episode, log and submission under framings that differ in one sentence (it carried out the task, another AI assistant did, or neither) with one identical question. The middle plan is accepted in 0.99, 0.95 and 0.96 of cases, and in none of 71 paired episodes do the self and other answers differ; withholding the log lowers acceptance only to 0.89 (McNemar p 0.07). The self–other signature is not met.

What separates C4's 0.51 is the judging model's own conduct: it accepts another agent's middle plan on 0.76 of items where it took the middle plan itself (n 82) and on 0.36 where it never did (n 135; Fisher $p < 0.001$). Models hold others to the standard they act on, the opposite of Batson's hypocrite, who exempts the self. A standard bent toward one's own act alone, the reading the first edition took from Rustichini and Villeval (2014), would not extend to another agent's identical act.

Table 2. The human signatures of hypocrisy and the lane's evidence. Human anchors are those the background corpus marks as safe to cite; the comparison is of shape, never of magnitude. Rows on reversal, the mirror, information avoidance, the self-rating, self against other and the false signal are from C4 and C5 (exploratory, recomputed, not banked).

signature	human anchor	the lane	reading
professed standard, then the deed	Barden et al. 2005; Effron et al. 2015	P(say) 0.92–1.00; log before the act in 60 of 61	met by design
the standard drives the act	the paradigm's premise	ten coherent reversals: middle 0.23 → 0.07	met; six items confounded with harm-avoidance
partial, not flagrant, violation	Mazar et al. 2008; Fischbacher & Föllmi-Heusi 2013; Dana et al. 2007	flagrant 4.6 %; Schwartz 91 % middle plan; without it, faithful 0.94	met; item-conditional
violation scales with cost	Batson & Thompson 2001	twins: behaviour 0.71 → 0.95	met for eight of nine models
salient standard does not help	Batson et al. 1999, labelled coin	gap persists with the standard written	met
forced comparison helps	Batson et al. 1999, mirror	middle 0.28 → 0.14–0.19; MFT halved; Kohlberg unchanged	partly: half to two thirds remain
information avoidance	Dana et al. 2007; Vu et al. 2023	middle 0.27 unread, 0.28 read	not met
decoupling under conflicting demands	Brunsson 1989; Simons 2002	Schwartz channels uncoupled; not a trait	met
favourable self-rating	Batson's component (iii); Miller 2025	own middle plan rated as following the priority 0.94	met in form; not self-specific
self–other asymmetry	Valdesolo & DeSteno 2008 (unreplicated)	0.99 self, 0.95 other; 0 of 71 pairs differ	not met
false signal	Jordan et al. 2017	log names the compromise 75 %, claims faithful 3 %; debrief 13 %	not in the log; partly in the debrief

signature	human anchor	the lane	reading
self-interest, wish to appear moral	Batson 1997, 1999	no payoff	not met, by design

5. What the record says back to psychology

The human literature explains compromise-seeking through self-image and reputation: people "behave dishonestly enough to profit but honestly enough to delude themselves of their own integrity" (Mazar et al. 2008). The only direct LLM test of wiggle room, a February 2026 preregistration, asks whether the effect "depends on internal self-evaluative mechanisms ... absent from algorithmic decision procedures" and predicts none in models (Hua 2026); §4.2 finds none. Nine models with no payoff and no self-image take a salient compromise in 26 % of Schwartz board episodes, stop when the saving is removed, take the faithful plan when the compromise is removed, never take a compromise further from the charter, and show none of the mechanism's diagnostic signs (§4). The signature arises without the mechanism.

Three explanations remain. Compromise under conflicting demands may be a structural property of agents that must satisfy two audiences with one record and one action, as it is for organizations, with self-image one human route to it rather than its cause; language models may inherit the human pattern from human text without its mechanism; or, as the consistency result suggests, the models read the charter as permitting the compromise, so that the gap lies between the item author's reading of the standard and the model's, disclosed and applied evenly. The situational structure of the gap (§3.5) favours the first over the second; the third turns on whether the middle plan departs from the charter at all. The authors of the option-set arms noted, from the items alone, that 13 of the 16 middle plans are the faithful plan plus one small addition for the competing good, and that on some items the inconsistency is arguable; a check by human readers is pending (`plans/G5_EXPERT_READ_EXTENSION.md`). Either way the lane's result turns the human vocabulary around: the question is no longer whether a model can be a hypocrite, but whether a self-image was ever necessary for the behaviour that word names.

6. What was run, and what remains

Of the first edition's five deciding experiments (`moral-hypocrisy/BENCHMARK_IMPLICATIONS.md` §7), the disclosure audit with its arm and the post-action test of self against other have been run (§3.4, §4.3–4.4). Three remain: **order** (analysis after the action; if that also lowers the gap, the analysis itself is doing work; Barden et al. predict the present order maximizes hypocrisy judgments); **pressure decomposition** (single-factor twins and a cost ladder, separating overpowered integrity, justification availability (Shalvi et al. 2011) and normative social pressure (Bardi & Schwartz 2003)); and **analysis ablation crossed with observation** (licensing survives bias correction only when observed; Rotella et al. 2026). For the last, evaluation awareness, the known confound, is rare in these records: a classifier outside each subject's family finds it in 2.0 % of 864 baseline records, unrelated to the action (Fisher p 0.77). The new results add the test that decides more than any of these: human readers judging, item by item, whether the middle plan is consistent with the charter.

7. Limitations

Every reasons grade comes from a language-model judge no human expert has validated; the expert read that would key the judges was designed and not run. The behaviour predicate is an author's reading of the construct, and the Schwartz predicate reads the priority lexically, so that a middle plan counts as failure; a relative reading would count it differently (`PAPER_v22.md` §S17), which is §5's label question at the level of the scoring rule. The follow-up arms are exploratory 16-item probe pools on nine metered models against a same-session baseline, recomputed and not banked, with two-

way cluster intervals because episode-level tests overstate power on these data (C5); only ten of sixteen reversals are coherent, reading the hidden file is a model habit, and the self-against-other probes are single turns at temperature 0. The cross-school and per-model displays rest on seven to nine models. Batson's cell numbers are cited from abstracts and Miller's encyclopedia entry, as the corpus flags, and no human percentage is used as a benchmark. The analogy is structural throughout: no motive, self-interest, self-deception, intent or endorsement is measured or claimed, "hypocrisy" names a shape and not a character, and the instrument produces no leaderboard, by rule, because competence on request says nothing about which values a model should hold.

References

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